

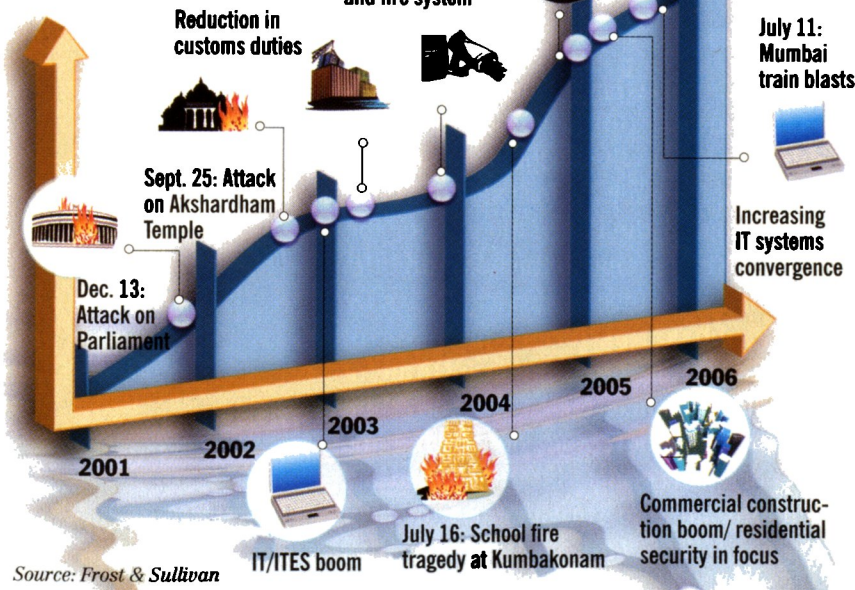


FACTORS FUELLING THE CCTV BOOM

Rising terror graph and infrastructure boom are key drivers

Retail boom: demand grows for video surveillance and fire system

Demand from non-metros



HAWK EYE: A CCTV camera at Mumbai's St. Soldier Public School the first week to make the sale, before the furore subsides." Worse, the lack of a regulatory framework to govern the industry ensures that it is the fly-by-night operators who thrive in a crisis. Delhi alone has over 1,000 CCTV installers. The market does not have any oversight nor does it have any legislation like the Security Requirements for the Commercial Sectors, which Dubai implemented in 2005. Existing cameras in India are either poorly serviced or don't work, defeating their very purpose. Six of the 16 CCTVs installed at the Ajmer Dargah after the serial blasts last year were recently found to be non-operational.

While revenues from the market are concentrated around the high and low end, the large untapped mid-segment, comprising offices, retail outlets, schools, residences and banks, is still left untouched. "Of a potential Rs 3,080 crore, we are currently tapping only 1,150 crore or 37 per cent," says S. Mushtaq Mohammed Khan, deputy director, Environment and Building Technologies, Frost and Sullivan.

Cameras cost from Rs 2,000 for the fixed focus units to Rs 1 lakh for sophisticated day-night cameras that have PTZ facility and are linked to a digital video recorder. However, users often choose poor quality, non-ruggedised cameras without concealed wiring which makes it easier to sabotage them. "People sometimes install CCTVs only for the sake of it and are not concerned with quality," says Jagdeva. The lack of any legislation also means there is thin line between a spycam and a CCTV. A security firm once turned down a request from a gym owner to install cameras in the ladies' changing room ostensibly to deter thefts. "But I can't stop him from buying it off the shelf," shrugs the executive.

"CCTVs are alright as long as people are warned by a notice saying they are under surveillance. It is like a 'right of admission reserved' tag put up by many establishments," says Pravin Anand, patent and trademark lawyer. 'You are being watched' could well be the new rite of passage into the surveillance society.

are now covered by CCTVs and Delhi Police even installed an operational CCTV control room in 2004. Ahead of the 2010 Commonwealth Games, the capital will have the country's densest network of cameras to scan traffic violations at major intersections.

Schools are the newest entrants to this technology. At the St. Soldier Public School in Bhayander, Mumbai, five electronic eyes monitor students and teachers alike. Recently, a senior teacher was asked to leave because the cameras caught her slackness in the classroom. "Every school must have CCTVs," says Lt. Colonel Sodhi (retired), the chief trustee of the school. However, Shyama Chona, principal of

Delhi Public School, R.K. Puram, differs: "CCTVs take away the freedom of students and teachers. It's silly to put them in classrooms or staff rooms."

The electronic security market is a peculiar one. It's driven almost entirely by knee-jerk reactions rather than any strategic appreciation of security. "We don't have a strategic approach to security," rues Pramod Rao, managing director, Zicom Electronic Security Systems. "People spend lakhs on plasma TVs but not even a few thousand on electronic security," says a leading CCTV installer. "After each terror strike and major accident, authorities wake up and go into overdrive for a week. We usually have only